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Faculty of Social Science & Humanities

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SECTION 52

TACKLING THE RISE OF CYBERSECURITY THREATS THROUGH EDUCATION AND AWARENESS

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1.0 INTRODUCTION

In recent years, cyber threats in Malaysia have seen a sharp rise. The expertise of cybercriminals is increasing, from malicious software attacks to phishing scams. This situation can be seen clearly in 2023, with over 10,000 cybersecurity incidents being reported in Malaysia. Apart from individuals, Businesses and governmental organizations are also targeted by these threats, which can result in significant financial losses and data breaches. The issues are critical as highlighted by the World Economic Forum's 2024 Global Risk Report, which rates cybersecurity as the fourth most important global risk for the next two years (Editor, 2025). However, many individuals and organizations in Malaysia still lack the education to identify or avoid these internet threats. A study by Odumesi (2015) revealed that 69.4% of the respondents were aware of cybersecurity, but only 37.8% had participated in any kind of awareness program. This demonstrates the significant gap between general knowledge and effective action. In response to this, this report investigates the causes and effects of increasing cybersecurity threats in Malaysia and proposes two potential solutions for educators and the public to reduce the risk of cybersecurity threats.

2.0 BACKGROUND OF THE PROBLEM

This part discusses the cause and effects of the problem.

2.1 Cause of The Problem

One of the main causes of the rise of cybersecurity cases is the lack of awareness and proficiency in technology among Malaysian internet users. Nowadays, society increasingly relies on the Internet for daily activities, including communication, online shopping, financial transactions, and accessing information (Ali & Zaharon, 2022). Their heavy dependence on digital platforms provides more opportunities for cybercriminals to subtly influence their opinions by spreading false information that weakens their awareness to prevent cyberattacks. Many people are unaware that a simple behavior like just clicking an unknown link, applying a weak password, or even using the same password for all platforms can expose them to phishing scams, identity

theft, or malware attacks. For instance, many users tend to trust the email or message in social media that seems official or familiar without checking the source. This false sense of trust puts them at a greater risk of being exposed to cybercrime.

2.2 Effects of The Problem

As a result of the growing number of cybersecurity risks, financial loss is among the most frequent effects for both individuals and organizations. Often, victims are unaware of the disclosure of sensitive information, such as bank numbers or account passwords. Therefore, without realizing it, they may have become victims of cybercrime. When there is a lack of awareness, it becomes difficult to detect or avoid such threats. For example, according to Rahman et al. (2020), Malaysia recorded over RM4.9 million in losses due to online fraud cases involving sectors like housing, tourism, and automobile sales.

In addition to financial losses, another severe implication of this problem would be identity theft. Once cybercriminals gain access to personal information, cybercriminals can use victim impersonation to conduct fraud, especially against the victim's family and friends, seek loans, or commit any other illegal behavior. For instance, Anderson et al. (2008) reported a case where a victim's identity was stolen and used to open multiple credit accounts without their knowledge. When the fraud was being caught,In a result the victim not only suffered financial losses but also had to go through a long and hard process of rebuilding credit and proving innocence.

3.0 POSSIBLE SOLUTIONS

This part describes the two possible solutions to the problem.

3.1 Cybersecurity Education in Schools

One effective solution to reduce cybersecurity threats in the long term is by integrating cybersecurity education into the school curriculum. School administrators and teachers can discuss together and organise school programmes or activities about cybersecurity (Rahman et al., 2020). Government funding allocated to schools specifically for educational improvement can help support these approaches. Besides, teachers are encouraged to adopt creative and interesting teaching methods, such as playing cartoons and storytelling about cybersecurity to engage younger students. It is more successful at achieving the goal of getting children to focus on listening than

boring lectures and talks. A good example would be using the story of Upin and Ipin to raise awareness among children about cybersecurity (Pitchan, Omar, & Ghazali, 2017).

The biggest advantage of this solution is that it can cultivate children's awareness of cybersecurity from an early age, laying a good foundation for their future safe online behavior. Over time, most students who have received relevant education will be much less at risk of cybercrime. However, this solution also has certain disadvantages. Teachers need to be well trained and receive correct and standardized training about cybersecurity to deliver correct and reliable knowledge to students. Additionally, teachers must continuously update their understanding to maintain the effectiveness and relevance of teaching content as cyber risks keep on changing.

3.2 Public Awareness Campaigns

The next suggestion to reduce cybersecurity threats is by conducting public awareness campaigns. Government agencies, private companies, or academic institutions should lead this kind of campaign to educate the public on common cyber threats and how to avoid them. Various activities including webinars, posters, television advertisements, community talks, and social media content can be implemented in the campaign. It is important for the public to recognize cybercrime, such as phishing, scams, and malware attacks, particularly in elderly and vulnerable groups who may not receive formal cybersecurity education.

The ability of public awareness campaigns to quickly reach a large audience through various platforms would be its main advantage. It makes people more cautious and lowers their chance of falling into a cybercrime. However, its disadvantage is that not everyone will take this information seriously or even apply it in real life. In addition, effective publicity campaigns require continuous funding, planning, and cooperation, which are difficult to maintain.

4.0 CONCLUSION

In conclusion, even though the internet has brought great convenience to everyday life, the rapid increase in cybersecurity threats in Malaysia has raised serious concerns. This report suggests two key solutions to the problems, which are implementing cybersecurity education in schools and organizing public awareness campaigns. These solutions are believed to provide an effective strategy that not only educates children about cybersecurity from a young age but also equips the

general public to recognize and protect against cyber threats. In conjunction with lowering the number of cybercrime cases, raising everyone's awareness of cybersecurity can make the internet more secure and reliable. In the long term, a society with strong cybersecurity knowledge will surely lead the country further in this digital age.

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APPENDIX

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TACKLING THE RISE OF CYBERSECURITY THREATS
THROUGH EDUCATION AND AWARENESS

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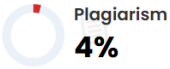

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